Timeline of the World

1939 — World War II begins

1943 — The Slinky spring toy is invented by engineer Richard James

1949 — The first NASCAR race is held in Charlotte, North Carolina

1950 — Charles M. Schulz's *Peanuts* comic strip first appears in newspapers

1959 — The Soviet space probe Luna 3 is the first to photograph the far side of the moon

1960 — American scientist Theodore H. Maiman builds the first laser

1970 — Earth Day is celebrated for the first time on April 22

1975 — Japanese mountain climber Junko Tabei becomes the first woman to reach the summit of Mt. Everest

1985 — American explorer Robert Ballard discovers the shipwreck of the *Titanic* in the Atlantic Ocean

1991 — Germans hiking along the Italy-Austria border discover a mummy of a man, now known as Ötzi, who was more than five thousand years old

2002 — Steve Fossett becomes the first person to fly around the world in a balloon alone, starting and ending in Australia

2012 — A huge hurricane, called Superstorm Sandy, hits the Caribbean and eastern United States and causes high winds, blizzard conditions, heavy rains, flooding, and massive destruction